

Reality is a historical process



Revolutions, especially the Haitian slave revolt in the 1790s, confirmed for Hegel the idea of a change in Spirit being a necessary part of social change.

Like Kant, Georg Hegel developed a ‘system’ of philosophy, but while building on Kant’s ideas, he corrected what he saw as fundamental errors in Kant’s thinking. Hegel dismissed the notion of a thing-in-itself as a mere abstraction, and argued that what exists is whatever is manifested in consciousness. Being, for Hegel, is a single and comprehensive whole within which a thinking subject – consciousness – and its object – the external world – are identical. What he called the *Geist*, or Spirit, encompasses everything in this essentially non-material reality, including our institutions and consciousness. Hegel also rejected the idea that Kant’s ‘categories’, our framework of experience, are distinct and unchanging. Instead, he believed that consciousness itself, and not just that which we are

conscious of, is subject to change and part of a process of evolution. We see changes in the world as the progress of history, but more than that, these are examples of changes in the Spirit as a whole: reality itself is a dynamic, historical process.